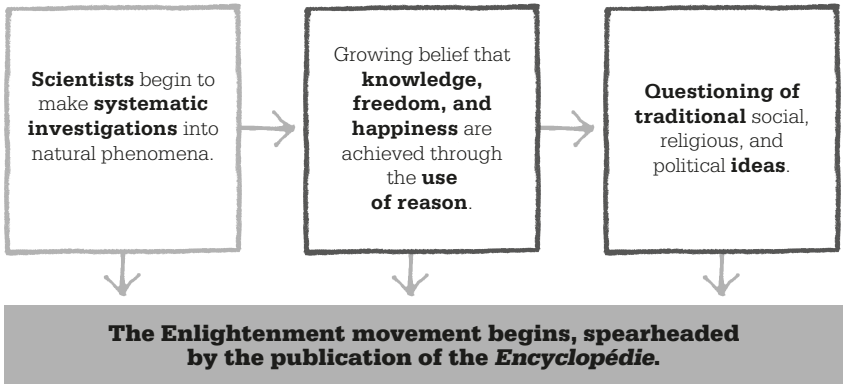




doctrines of the Catholic Church but on rational thought; the importance of observations and experiments in science; and the search for a way of organizing states and governments around natural law and justice.

Diderot organized the *Encyclopédie*'s articles into three main categories: memory (subjects connected to history); reason (philosophy); and imagination (poetry). Controversially, there was no special category for God or the divine—religion, like magic and superstition, was treated as part of philosophy. This approach was groundbreaking, and contentious. Religion had been at the very heart of life and thought in Europe for centuries: the *Encyclopédie*, and the Enlightenment itself, denied it this key position.

In spite of repeated efforts by the authorities to censor some of its articles, and to intimidate and threaten its editors, the *Encyclopédie* became the most influential and widely consulted work of the period. The ideas that it transmitted inspired the revolutions that exploded in France and the US at the end of the 18th century.

Science and reason

The Enlightenment movement was characterized by a focus on the power of human reason and skepticism of accepted knowledge. This marked a break from earlier generations in which beliefs about the world derived from religious teachings and the doctrines of the Church. These

governed everything from the laws of marriage to the way people understood the movement of the planets and the creation of the universe. For Enlightenment thinkers, however, the evidence of a person's senses and the use of one's reason was far more important than their blind adherence to a faith. They argued that "truths" about the tangible world, which had been set down in antiquity by Aristotle and others, and upheld by the Church, should be tested through experimentation and observation, checked, and then discussed in a rational way.

This radical mode of thinking had its origins in the scientific revolution of the 17th century. Scientists and philosophers including Francis Bacon, Johannes Kepler, Isaac Newton, and Galileo Galilei had transformed the study of nature and the physical universe, making it more observational. They conducted careful experiments and subjected their results to mathematical analysis; in the process they drastically updated and expanded the fields of physics, chemistry, biology, and astronomy. »

“Dare to know! Have courage to use your own reason!”
Immanuel Kant
 “What is Enlightenment?” (1784)